

Creative Brief: CRT System Startup

Core Concept

The animation presents a retro computer terminal booting up, but with signs of instability. It begins with a CRT-style power-on glow, followed by a blinking pixel, glitching visuals, and a pixelated loading sequence. After a brief scan across the screen, the system stabilizes and displays “SYSTEM ONLINE,” suggesting the machine has successfully completed its startup process.

Visual Theme

The visual style is based on classic CRT monitors and early computer terminals. A black background paired with bright green graphics creates for a strong retro aesthetic. Effects such as glow and scanlines and flickering opacity are used to simulate the imperfections of an old tube display.

Reason for Choosing the Concept

This concept was chosen because it combines a clear visual direction with a strong connection to technology and some motion graphics. It also let me dive deeper into After Effects and get more familiar with the software.

Intended Mood and Feeling

The animation is meant to feel technical, retro, and slightly unstable. The early stages of the sequence create tension through flickering and glitches, while the final “SYSTEM ONLINE” moment provides a sense of completion and stability.

Target Audience

The target audience includes viewers interested in retro technology, computer interfaces, and digital aesthetics. It would appeal to people who enjoy glitch visuals, sci-fi themes, or terminal-style graphics.

Possible Applications and Uses

This animation could be used as an intro sequence, transition, or title card in videos. It would also fit well in gaming content, tech-related media, or sci-fi projects where a system startup or digital interface is needed.

Main Visual Elements

Key elements include the CRT power-on glow, blinking pixel, glitch sequences, loading bar, scan line, and final text reveal. Each element represents a stage in the system startup process and contributes to the overall progression of the animation.

Animation Techniques Used

The project uses shape and text layers combined with opacity, scale, and position animation. An alpha mask is used to reveal the final text, while precomposition is used to organize the glitch sequence. Additional effects such as glow and blending modes help create the CRT appearance.

Font Choice

OCR B was selected for its structured, machine-like appearance. Its clean and readable design supports the idea of a computer-generated interface.

Color Choice

The green-on-black color scheme was chosen to reflect classic terminal displays. The bright green stands out clearly against the dark background and reinforces the retro computer theme.

New Sequence

After building the animation in After Effects, some timing and order changed slightly because the original arrangement did not feel as strong once animated. The final version keeps the same core visual beats and CRT-inspired theme, but the sequence was adjusted to make the motion feel more natural and visually balanced.

The animation follows this sequence:

1. CRT glow / power-on effect
2. Blinking pixel
3. Glitch precomposition
4. Blank screen moment
5. Pixelated loading bar
6. Short second glitch
7. Animated scan line
8. "SYSTEM ONLINE" alpha mask reveal

Challenges

One of the main challenges was creating effects that felt authentic without becoming overly complex. The CRT look required getting the glow right, while the glitch sequence needed to appear chaotic but still readable. The loading bar also needed careful timing to feel natural.

Fin.

The final animation runs for 10 seconds and 13 frames, and i'm pretty proud of how it turned out.